

Hidden gems: TNPL gave Rajalingam S — and many others — a stage to shine, far from the IPL's glare but no less intense. TNPL



reached the final but lost to Maratha Royals — a team without any international stars.

"We have an enviable pool of local talents," said Maratha Royals captain Siddhesh Lad. Several youngsters stood out under his leadership — including off-spin all-rounder Maxwell Swaminathan, who shares his name with the Australian star. Despite playing age-group cricket for Mumbai and being active at the club level, Swaminathan gained wider attention thanks to his eight wickets in six games. His improvement owes much to his time as a Mumbai Indians net bowler. "He (Suryakumar) faces me a lot in the nets and I keep asking him which is the area that I should try bowling at? He suggests a few things... and I just try to put those suggestions into practice," said Swaminathan, who hails from Ghatkopar. But had he met his famous namesake?

Maxwell smiled, "Yes, I did meet Glenn Maxwell once." A couple of years ago at a Mumbai Indians nets session, he bumped into the Aussie,

took an autograph, and left with a memory. "He was surprised to know that we share the same name and that I'm also a spinner all-rounder," Swaminathan said.

Shayan Acharya

Stepping out of comfort zone

Four massive floodlight towers visible from over a kilometre away. Giant billboards outside the ground. A crowd trying to get in through a single gate.

The Ramakrishna Arts and Science College ground has hosted TNPL for four years, but this was the Diary's first live match experience in his hometown, Coimbatore.

With only the dressing rooms being permanent, the transformation of the venue was striking. Metal frames, wooden planks, makeshift enclosures for officials, media, and corporate guests — the familiar turf looked entirely new.

The city's cool evening breeze set the mood for a packed house, especially during Lyca Kovai Kings'

matches.

TNPL continues to be a launchpad for little-known players. Early games in the 2025 season featured impressive debut outings from a few.

Playing under lights, in front of hundreds — sometimes thousands — with blaring music is outside many players' comfort zones. So is facing cameras and post-match interviews.

Siechem Madurai Panthers pacer Rajalingam S (3-0-27-0), fresh from a win on debut, entered the press room for the first time. Only three people were present, but he looked uneasy, especially with a mic in hand.

"*Kashtamana kelvi kepeengala na* (Will you ask tough questions)," he asked, sheepishly.

What followed was a disarmingly honest 10-minute chat — a refreshing break from the usual media-coached clichés.

"*Nalla pesunen ah?* (Did I speak well?)," he asked on his way out, drawing laughs from everyone in the room.

Anish Pathiyil